NO DISCIPLINE: AN INTRODUCTION TO "THE INDISCIPLINE OF COMPARISON"

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> comparison is not a method or even an academic technique; rather, it is a discursive strategy
>
> —Benedict Anderson, *A Life beyond Boundaries*

In the run-up to Brexit, Martin Amis hailed the coming splendid isolation of the United Kingdom as quite proper to the English language's proven literary superiority: "there's no earthly reason why anyone in the Anglosphere should desperately want to learn a foreign language," because English is "a much more evolved language, with something like five times the vocabulary of Spanish."[1]

Amis presents a caricature of the layperson's view of our discipline: comparative literature as the ranking of the world's literatures—a project on a par with the ever more pervasive global rankings of everything from universities to hamburgers. Yet in his literary chauvinism and appeals to proven literary value, Amis comes a poor second to Russian conceptual writer and artist Dmitrii Prigov, who a decade earlier published his more mathematically precise literary world rankings:

> Если достоинства русской литературы обозначить через 1, то китайская потянет на 0,99. Немецкая на 0,89. Английская на 0,87. Французская на 0,785. Испанская и итальянская на 0,75 каждая. Я потяну на 0,31. Отсвет от русской литературы, могущий быть оцененным в 0,05, дает в сумме с моим личным показателем 0,36—что совсем неплохо. Даже чистый нуль у нас, учитывая отсвет в 0,05, имеет положительное значение.[2]

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> (If the worth of Russian literature is defined as 1, then Chinese reaches 0.99. German 0.89. English 0.87. French 0.785. Spanish and Italian each reach 0.75. I reach 0.31. The reflected glory of Russian literature, which might be valued at 0.05, summed with my personal figure gives 0.36—which is not bad at all. Even a pure zero in Russia, taking into consideration the reflected glory of 0.05, has a positive value.)

Prigov builds his absurd ranking system by conjoining literature with mathematical figures and with the banal national and linguistic chauvinism that Amis reiterates. Prigov takes Amis-like literary chauvinism and border guarding to self-undermining extremes. He thereby transforms evaluative nationalistic comparison into comparative national chauvinisms, generating humor through the reader's familiarity with such assertions of national superiority—be they Russian or English. Prigov's border-collapsing humor equally relies on the faux precision of his figures; in other words, on his application of the quantitative language of mathematics to a traditionally qualitative discipline.

If Prigov humorously collapses borders and imagines, like John Lennon, a world with "no countries," he equally rewrites Lennon to offer a world without disciplines.[3] Just as Prigov intertwines national with disciplinary border crossing, so the premise of this special issue is that these two kinds of border crossing are constitutive of comparative literature, or at least of comparison as we might imagine it.

To the fantasy of a world without constraint, however, we have Jean Ricardou's cool riposte, published in the same year as Lennon's song: "if everything is allowed, nothing is possible."[4] Literature deploys constraints of vocabulary, letters, line numbers, layout, medium, and so on. Prigov's text, for example, is built from a simple rule that combines national literatures with numerical figures. Likewise, any discipline, even a discipline like comparative literature, requires norms, standards of evidence, agreed objects of inquiry, measures of quality, and modes of delineating the field. We need constraints, norms, shared disciplinary frameworks, and standards in order to say anything and in order to be understood. In freedom, limits; in limits, freedom.

As a leading writer and theorist of the *nouveau roman*, however, Ricardou's contribution to literature was anything but about repeating old disciplinary norms. The same is true of his compatriot Oulipo writers, who similarly emphasized constraint over freedom. While the Oulipo writers did seek inspiration from tried and true forms of constraint—the sonnet, the villanelle, the sestina—their most important contribution to literature was

their invention of new constraints, new rules by which poems and stories could be written. The Oulipo writers imagined literature not as a set of texts following generic and disciplinary norms, but as a process of continuously rewriting the rule book. Oulipo writers arguably located the creative act not primarily in the writing of new literary works but in the writing of new constraints.[5] Literature, in other words, doesn't just need indiscipline: indiscipline is literature's defining quality. Not no discipline exactly, but no discipline without indiscipline—no living literature without the constant reinvention of its forms and norms.

Comparative literature might equally be envisaged as a discipline forged from indiscipline. The history of the field has been characterized by an energetic effort to change the rules of the game. The current generation of comparatists has continued this tradition from Franco Moretti's data-driven "distant reading" to Eric Hayot's rejection of periodization as a disciplinary imperative to Susan Stanford Friedman's advocacy of modernist "collage" as a model for eclectic comparison.[6] These innovators tend to frame their proposals as attacks on existing disciplinary norms. Moretti, for instance, presents his distant reading approach as an escape from the geographic, linguistic, and qualitative disciplinary straightjacket of comparative literature as it has been practiced: a "modest intellectual enterprise" that has not lived up to the initial promise of Goethe and Marx but which is instead "fundamentally limited to Western Europe, and mostly revolving around the river Rhine (German philologists working on French literature)."[7]

As Ricardou's caution reminds us, of course, making new rules or reapplying old rules in new places is quite different from dispensing with rules altogether. Indeed, there is nothing more disciplinary than efforts to highlight and change disciplinary limits. Interdisciplinary approaches similarly exist only in relation to disciplines: "the prominence of disciplines gives interdisciplinarity its meaning and power." Both interdisciplinarity and transnationalism "illustrate a given definition's immanent boundaries—rather than escaping it, they constitute it as a system."[8] Comparative literature in particular fills the cracks between disciplinary and national boundaries, giving definition and outline to the borders it crosses.

Comparative literature, in other words, does not dispense with rules or disciplines but helps us perceive those rules or disciplines more clearly. Through interdisciplinary and transnational approaches, comparative literature makes explicit the implicit disciplinary assumptions and national paradigms of literary studies. Moretti, for example, reveals the assumptions and blind spots of qualitative approaches to literary studies by highlighting a quantitative alternative. He does repeat certain disciplinary conventions,

such as "the near-total dominance of the concept of periodization in literary studies" and concomitant "covert assumptions about space that privilege one location over others," leading "unthinkingly into binaries of center/periphery."[9] However, Moretti equally questions the disciplinary norms of the literary object and mode of inquiry: instead of individual literary works, the object becomes a corpus of works; instead of close reading, we tabulate coded data and run experiments. In throwing off one discipline's blind spots of course, Moretti reiterates another's: quantitative social science's tendency to elide or at least downplay the interpretative process of coding that produces its numerical objects in the first place.

Nevertheless, Moretti demonstrates the fertile possibilities of disciplinary renewal through the adaptation of the rules of one discipline to another, where they may appear strikingly new and overturn ingrained disciplinary modes of thought. We can see similar gains in the efforts to rethink literary studies today on a wider spatial and temporal scale by drawing on disciplines such as geography and global history. Here, the push and pull of competing approaches within a discipline functions, at least in principle, to correct each approach's blind spots, by allowing an "open (and sometimes hostile) dialogue on the viabilities of its major methodological choices."[10] Like the Oulipo project to make the rules of literary production explicit and subject to continuous innovation, comparative literature depends on explicating and renovating the rules of the game.

New constraints—new acts of indiscipline—bring estranging effects even as they foretell new disciplinary norms. The process here might be likened to Iurii Tynianov's extension of estrangement to an account of literary history via an analogy with another discipline: evolutionary biology. In "literary evolution," Tynianov says, the norms of one generation—both those literary or "formal elements" that are "dominant" and those that have been subject to "automatization" and become "auxiliary"—are estranged (redeployed to fulfill a new "function") by the next generation. The new norms then become the orthodoxy in turn to be overthrown, as the function of elements in the "literary system" is again rearranged.[11] Similarly, undisciplined and interdisciplinary thought is part of—not external to—the disciplinary system: it serves both to defy and redefine disciplines.

If disciplines change through acts of disciplinary estrangement or indiscipline, then comparison would seem the tool of disciplinary change par excellence. After all, one test for comparisons is whether they can shock us into new ways of seeing the world. As Benedict Anderson argues, "the most instructive comparisons (whether of difference or similarity) are those that surprise."[12] Comparison, Rita Felski writes in this issue,

offers a "jolt to consciousness" and a "sense of the limits of one's own perspective."[13] Think, for example, of C. L. R. James's radical series of comparative gestures in *Beyond a Boundary*. James compares cricket to Ancient Greek athletics and contextualizes the sport through the British class and imperial system and the history of colonialism and nationalism in the Caribbean. In what is arguably a foundational text of cultural studies, James surprises by showing how cricket functions as a crucial vehicle for ideology, a means to a "more complete human existence," and a key medium for the collective imagining of the Anglophone Caribbean.[14] Twenty years before Anderson, James's surprising comparisons reveal how sports as much as books shaped the making of imagined communities in the age of European empires and beyond.

But if the surprise generated by comparison is, as Anderson would have it, a "discursive strategy," rather than a "method" or an "academic technique," then does it make sense to think of comparative literature as a discipline at all?[15] And if disciplines are only apprehended through interdisciplinary practices, then not only is comparative literature not a discipline, but there is no discipline as such. No discipline can be recognized in isolation, but only through comparison and indiscipline.

Here, I adapt the words of Craig Dworkin, who writes: "there is no 'medium.' No single medium can be apprehended in isolation."[16] Are disciplines like media? The term *medium* is often used as "a synonym for *genre* or *discipline*," and at first glance the analogy seems appealing in its simplicity.[17] Like a discipline, a medium imposes constraints and other norms: only so many minutes on an LP, only so many words per page, and so on. But media are strange things. Media name not just technologies but various forms of "cultural practice."[18] The "first phonograph distribution companies" were "all but oblivious to the rising tide of mechanical amusement." For them, the commercial possibilities and "the unquestioned, utilitarian purpose of the phonograph/graphophone" lay in the dictation of business letters.[19] Instead, Thomas Edison's invention gave birth to a medium indelibly associated with the rise of popular music. Similarly, Dworkin argues that "the closer one looks at the materiality of a work . . . the more sharply a social context is brought into focus."[20] The more precisely one attempts to define a medium's material and social characteristics, the more the concept of medium disintegrates. We are left, finally, with the particularities of the individual work on a singular occasion of reading, listening, or viewing. System, constraint, and context collapse into nominalist singularity. Media can only be defined in relation to each other. Media describe not intrinsic qualities but relational categories. Hence, no medium.

Contemporary art and literature likewise exceed the boundaries of any single medium. Many Oulipo writers focused on the constraints of the alphabetic code: texts without a certain letter or letters (lipograms), texts in which each line contains one more letter (the "snowball" constraint), and so on.[21] But contemporary writers are also likely to emphasize the constraints of media. Contemporary poet and artist Caroline Bergvall, for example, exploits the relationship between recto and verso pages, the voice prints of multiple speakers, and the two sides of a wall in a gallery space in the print, audio, and mixed-media installation versions of her work "Cropper."[22] Moving easily between gallery, poetry reading, and printed page, such works reflect the "post-medium condition" of contemporary art.[23]

Are we similarly entering an age of post-discipline comparison? Or at least, would it be fruitful to think of comparative work as having no discipline but the singular set of rules and constraints that constitute the work and that define its relation to a range of disciplines? The articles here collectively make the argument for the work of comparison not as a single discipline but as a discursive strategy for engaging and rethinking disciplinary relations. The key test for such work would be not just whether it changes the rules of the game within a discipline but whether it alters the relationship between disciplines, surprising us into a new way of seeing the world.

The articles collected here grew in part out of my collaboration with scholars from other disciplines through the University of Otago Comparative and Cross-Cultural Studies Research Theme. Takashi Shogimen, Jing-Bao Nie, and I established this research group to generate discussion across a range of disciplines from bioethics to history, psychology to literature, anthropology to neuroscience. Through this research group, the University of Otago De Carle Distinguished Lectureship, and the University of Otago Asian Migrations Research Theme, three contributors to this issue, Haun Saussy, Shu-mei Shih, and Zhang Longxi, visited Otago and contributed to our interdisciplinary discussion about comparison.

In participating in this discussion, I was struck by two things: first, how stimulating and valuable real dialogue across disciplines can be; and second, how difficult it is to translate this dialogue into scholarship that has an impact on a field or ideally multiple fields. In order to have an influence on a field, interdisciplinary thought usually has to be framed within the context of a single discipline. Most interdisciplinary work reveals its disciplinary commitments through and through. In a sense, this special issue illustrates the point. Here I position a discussion of interdisciplinary thought within the disciplinary context of comparative literature, while my colleagues Jing-Bao Nie and Ruth Fitzgerald have chosen to initiate a similar discussion

in a journal devoted to bioethics.[24] Even if scholars from very different disciplines find enough common ground to initiate a conversation, they can only establish its significance, publish their work, and receive recognition through institutions that are primarily disciplinary. The same holds for other institutional structures, such as academic positions. Almost all positions on the academic job market are located within a single discipline or teaching program. Even in the case of jobs that explicitly appeal to candidates across a range of disciplines, the successful candidate will usually be hosted within a single department.

While institutional structures today work against true dialogue between disciplines, Haun Saussy opens this special issue by arguing that this was not always so, that comparative literature emerged from the fluid boundaries and widespread borrowing between disciplines that characterized eighteenth-century European thought. Saussy cites the possible, though seemingly improbable, example of comparative literature emerging from the little known field of comparative astronomy. Saussy argues that world literature today is symptomatic of the relinquishing of comparative literature's interdisciplinary origins in favor of the disciplinary orthodoxy of the English department and global English.

Coming to the defense of world literature, a discipline that he has done so much to promote and propagate, David Damrosch responds by rejecting the pitting of interdisciplinary comparison against the cross-cultural and interlingual comparisons of world literature. Damrosch argues that the two modes of comparison frequently and fruitfully go hand in hand. He also questions the shock value and historical veracity of Saussy's conjunction of astronomy and literature.

There may be stronger historical arguments for locating the eighteenth-century origins of comparative and world literature in the rise of biblical studies, as Damrosch argues, or in the church's shifting social function as reflected in "religion's relation to literature and philosophy," as Simon During has suggested.[25] However, from Copernicus to Einstein and Boas, the transdisciplinary recognition of relativity to which Saussy appeals has transformed our view of culture and the universe and surely remains important to the future as well as the past of our discipline.

In stressing, respectively, studied and shocking comparison, Damrosch and Saussy together help clarify the dangers of having no discipline and having too much discipline. In their dialogue, Damrosch and Saussy both take turns in espousing and deriding disciplinary rigidity. Damrosch attacks Saussy on disciplinary grounds, accusing him of "dilettantism and superficiality."[26] Yet Saussy equally questions Damrosch's disciplinary

commitment to one of the most vexed and hotly debated disciplinary norms in our field: the commitment to reading texts in their original languages rather than in translation. Saussy reinforces comparative literature's disciplinary prohibition on translation in his criticism of Damrosch's vision of world literature for threatening to reduce "all language and literature departments to subsets of the English department."[27]

Damrosch has elsewhere explored the history of the disciplinary prohibition on translation. He argues that "a deep divide between comparative literature and world literature" emerged in the 1950s, when "world literature courses began to gain visibility in the United States." Comparative literature scholars at "elite East Coast schools with strong language departments" looked down on the Midwestern monolingual world literature programs, whose "thriving new survey courses" they attacked "as linguistically and culturally amateurish."[28] However, it was the relative dilettantism of the Midwestern programs and scholars—as well as their relatively lower cultural capital and peripheral geographic positions—that allowed them to explore a far greater range of literatures than was possible for comparative literature scholars, who were expected to read all texts in the original languages and whose literary and linguistic focus remained largely confined to Western Europe. Citing and building on their example, Damrosch has been a passionate advocate for broadening the geographical and linguistic reach of comparative literature by reading at least some of the literatures of the world in translation.

While both Damrosch and Saussy maintain a commitment to comparison as a discipline—each accusing the other of insufficient discipline—they also suggest the importance of surprising acts of indiscipline. Their dialogue underscores that comparison is better understood not as a discipline at all but as a discursive strategy. Together, Damrosch and Saussy demonstrate the productive push and pull of comparison as a mode of discourse, in which each disciplinary or cultural position serves to highlight and question the assumptions of the other.

Where Damrosch and Saussy mainly address the European history of comparative literature, Karen Thornber explores the dangers of discipline by looking beyond a Eurocentric and a literary framework. While Damrosch might criticize Saussy's lack of discipline, Thornber argues that "comparatists have remained culturally, geographically, and linguistically disciplined; they have tapped only a fraction of the vast array of extant global literary production, mainly confining themselves to a relatively limited corpus of texts and languages."[29] Thornber locates the dangers of disciplinary rigidity in the geographical and linguistic narrowness of comparative literature as it has been

practiced in the Euro-American world. Thornber rightly points to the lack (at least in the Anglo-European academy) of comparative work on the literatures of most of the world and in particular of Africa, predicted to rival Asia as the world's most populous continent in the next century.[30] Equally in need of overturning is the tendency of our discipline to undertake comparative work on other parts of the world only in relation to European and Anglo-American literatures. Thornber argues that we need to abandon the disciplinary term "literature" along with the discipline's Eurocentric legacy in order to escape "the field's relative confinement" and open up an expanded terrain of comparison. Taking up this challenge, Thornber jettisons the disciplinary and geographic status quo through an ambitious exploration of Chinese-African relations over several centuries.

Thornber seeks to "break discipline more thoroughly" by appealing to yet another discipline: global history, which she describes as a "thriving interdisciplinary endeavor that examines interactions and links among world areas, identifying and analyzing the events, relationships, networks, and processes that have crossed national and regional boundaries."[31] This network or relational model of global history resembles the "circulation model" that has shaped the field of comparative literature over the past two decades. In both disciplines, global history and comparative literature, circulation has competed with the "center/periphery model" popularized by the historical economics of Immanuel Wallerstein's world-systems theory.[32] To the new global history that Thornber cites, we might add, for example, the work of scholars such as Tony Ballantyne, James Belich, and Isabel Hofmeyr, who have demonstrated how European imperial histories can be redescribed as dynamic fields of global interrelationship that do not just take place through the European metropole and its colonies but produce a web of relations between various parts of the world.[33] Already deeply connected through empire and the information revolution of the nineteenth century, the links between countries such as India and South Africa, China and Nigeria have redoubled in the twenty-first century through new waves of communication media and economic and cultural globalization.[34]

Thornber is not alone in turning to history to develop an expanded sense of comparison beyond the boundaries of a single discipline or region. Shu-mei Shih also cites world or global history as crucial to understanding the interconnectedness of historical and geographic position and interdisciplinary thinking. Shih argues that literary and cultural "theory arises out of relations in world history"[35] and that we can see how history shapes theory most clearly in a small nation like Taiwan, a relatively wealthy settler society that has close affiliations with the two dominant global empires of

the present moment. As a settler society, like the United States before it, Taiwan has a love–hate relationship to its colonial masters and so an ability to recognize the blind spots of their imperial positions: "As places where world historical power relations were most acutely felt, these small nations like Taiwan are paradoxically endowed with specific epistemic privileges out of conditions of intellectual poverty, rather than richness."[36] Taiwan provides an exemplary site for what Shih calls "relational comparison."[37] Relational comparison involves the recognition that every cultural practice—in this case, literature and cultural theory from Taiwan—is inseparable from the network of global interconnections that world history describes. Thus theory in Taiwan reflects the country's relationship to the United States, where most Taiwanese literary and cultural theorists have studied. In this respect, Taiwanese theorists are in the position of the colonized, but they are largely also participants in a Chinese colonial settler society that is itself further split by the country's complex history of settler colonialism and repeated invasion. In her account of Taiwanese theory, Shih adopts elements of both the circulation and center-periphery models of global history. Taiwan and Taiwanese theory become, in other words, both nodes on the complex network of global theoretical traffic and peripheries shaped by imperial centers such as New York, Tokyo, and Beijing.

How might these competing models of global history and economics reflect different ways of reading and different modes of comparison? That seems to be the implicit question behind Felski's article, which takes to task the overemphasis on suspicious reading within literary studies. As Felski has explained elsewhere, suspicious reading often involves uncovering the political and economic power structures underlying literary texts "in order to expose their hidden biases" and their "role in either obscuring or accentuating social antagonisms."[38] In this issue, Felski argues that suspicious reading tends to restrict—and in this sense discipline—comparison by subjecting it to "stringent critique," by accusing it "of imposing false equivalences and oppressive forms of homogenization."[39] Because it likewise stresses unequal power relations, suspicious reading might be the interpretative correlative of world-systems theory and the corresponding center/periphery model of global comparison.

Certainly, Felski's alternative to suspicious reading chimes with the most prominent alternative model for comparative and world literature: the flat, network-like relational model of global circulation. Like Shih, Felski derives her relational model for comparison from another discipline. But rather than turning to history, Felski looks to sociology. Felski finds her

relational mode of comparison in the actor-network theory of sociologist Bruno Latour. Drawing on actor-network theory, Felski proposes a mode of comparison that stresses not "againstness" but relations as "inescapable conditions of being." Such a comparative mode again opposes disciplinary isolation. Instead of emphasizing "the singularity of the literary work," Felski approaches literature as a "virtual machine for generating comparisons." Like Thornber and Shih, Felski proposes not a new modus operandi for the discipline of comparative literature but an expanded vision of comparison: comparison not as a discipline but as "a ubiquitous aspect of thought."[40]

Zhang Longxi offers an equally expansive vision of the work of comparison. He argues that "the holistic worldview embodied in analogical thinking, which relates everything to everything else in a complicated system of correspondences, may be helpful precisely because of its difference from our conventional 'scientific' way of thinking about the world." Zhang draws on a long tradition of analogical thought ("found almost universally in the ancient world, not just in China") to combat "increasingly specialized areas of different disciplines that tend to compartmentalize our knowledge rather than to see the different parts and dimensions of our world as correlated as a whole." Comparison becomes the common ground of all disciplines: "all disciplines and areas of study share a fundamental methodological and epistemological given—namely comparison, which subtends all efforts at learning and knowledge."[41]

Zhang's "analogical thinking" functions something like the surprise or shock that Anderson, Saussy, and Felski value in comparison. Comparison here is again no discipline at all but rather a mode of thought or a discursive strategy that reveals and unsettles disciplinary boundaries, making us look twice at our disciplines and at the world. As the articles in this issue attest, we as comparatists have much to gain by turning our apparent lack of discipline from a weakness into a strength, and even more by unleashing the power of comparison to generate new ways of imagining the world.

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Notes

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